BAPPI LAHIRI – 1952-2022

The Ultimate Showman

Bappi Lahiri brought in musical influences from across the world to give us some timeless Bollywood classics

By Tanishk Bagchi

Bappi Lahiri or Bappi da, as he was known to everyone, stayed musically ahead of the curve by bringing new trends to Bollywood. He introduced disco and electro pop beats to Hindi music, giving us songs that we are dancing to till date. And to have done this when composers didn't even have the luxury of platforms like YouTube and Spotify, which make international music easily accessible, is all the more impressive. He heard music from across the world and invested time to be in sync with what the world was doing. As much as the West inspired him, his music was equally commercial Bollywood. Just listen to '*Aaj Rapat Jaayen To*' from *Namak Halal*. Coming from a musical family from West Bengal, there's a lot of Bengali folk influence in his music too.

He was an adept tabla player himself and was open to different kinds of voices and instruments. Nowadays when one singer's career takes off, composers rush to him or her. Bappi Da wasn't like that. He would seek out new singers, ones who hadn't necessarily made a name for themselves till then. Every singer he introduced had a unique voice. He created beautiful tunes with just the right voices to bring them to life, like Salma Agha in '*Jhoom Jhoom Jhoom Baba*' (*Kasam Paida Karne Wale Ki*). Recently, when I heard the song play out to the trailer of the Hollywood film *Guardians of the Galaxy Vol 2*, I felt it could have easily been mistaken for a contemporary track, like a Dua Lipa song. This was no remix or cover and it still sounded so fresh. I'm sure that there was a dancer hidden inside Bappi da. How else could someone have created so many foot-tapping melodies and get the groove right every time?

When Bappi da heard that I had recreated his superhit song '*Tamma Tamma Loge*' (*Thanedaar*) for *Badrinath ki Dulhania*, he called and I was surprised at how he knew everything about my career. He was very happy. He asked me to come home and have *roshogolla*. I made it a point to retain his voice for the new version of '*Tamma Tamma*'. I just knew the song's appeal and success were intricately linked to his rendition. After hearing his voice several times, I realised that no one can sing the way he does. When Bappi Da sang a Hindi song, he was like, "I am Bappi da. I am a Bengali guy, so if some Hindi words come with a Bengali twang, so be it." It was the sweetest part of his singing and you can't copy that. I had reached out to him just before the first lockdown. I wanted to get disco back, but with a twist. And who could be better than Bappi da to collaborate on this with? I still have his message: "Anytime you call me, I am here only. I will come and jam and we will make something."



Illustration by NILANJAN DAS

He was a true showman of the composing world. Artists these days groom themselves to become something they are not. They work out or do some dance so that people follow them on Instagram. They don't enjoy their own selves. What set Bappi da apart was that he enjoyed himself. He was comfortable in his own skin. He knew he was the star. He always wore his aura on his sleeve. He didn't need a publicist or marketing strategy to promote himself.

This is why he was one legend who always inspired and encouraged me. He belongs to an esteemed rank of composers whose work will last for generations to come. We all instantly remember his face when his songs play. That's the mark of a true legend. That's how history is made. ■

Tanishk Bagchi *is the popular composer behind one of 2021's biggest hits* 'Raataan Lambiyan'. *He also recreated Bappi Lahiri's iconic* 'Tamma Tamma Loge' *(As told to Suhani Singh)*